

GRADE 8 · READING LITERATURE · RL.8.5

Match Point, Told Two Ways

Compare the structure of two literary texts describing the same event, and analyze how each text's structure shapes its meaning and style.

Lesson Map · Passage · Guided · Partner · Independent Practice · Small Group · Answer Key

What You Will Learn Today

Learning Goals

Understand RL.8.5: Compare the structure of two literary texts describing the same event,...

Read an original passage closely

Support every answer with text evidence

Work through guided, partner, and independent practice

How the Lesson Runs

Warm-up and passage

Guided practice together

Partner discussion

Independent + small-group work

Exit ticket and answer key

Unpacking the Standard

Structure is the order and arrangement of events in a text, not the events themselves. Chronological structure moves start to finish in time order. Other structures — starting near the end and flashing back, or jumping between moments — can create suspense, emphasize a specific moment, or change what the reader focuses on, even when telling the exact same story.

Modeled Example

A story about a car accident could be told start-to-finish, or it could open with the ambulance arriving and then flash back to what led up to it. What effect does opening with the ambulance create that starting from the beginning would not?

Opening with the ambulance immediately signals to the reader that something serious happens, creating tension and curiosity about how the characters got there, an effect a purely chronological version would build toward more slowly.

If two texts describe the same graduation ceremony, but one is organized chronologically and the other is organized by "before/during/after" reflections from one character, how might their styles differ?

The chronological version would likely read as a straightforward narrative account, while the reflective version would likely feel more personal and introspective, focused on the character's emotional experience rather than the sequence of events itself.

Match Point (Told in Order)

1. Deja had lost the first two games of the match to Vikram, the top seed at the regional chess tournament, and by the third game she was down a rook with no clear plan to get it back. She reset her water bottle cap three times before making her next move, a habit her coach called "stalling with style."
2. On move nineteen, Vikram offered a pawn trade that looked harmless. Deja stared at the board for four full minutes, longer than she had spent on any move that day, before declining it and repositioning her knight instead.
3. Vikram's eyebrows rose slightly, the first visible reaction he had shown all match. He had expected the trade to be accepted automatically; declining it meant Deja had seen something in the position he had not expected her to see.
4. Seven moves later, Deja's repositioned knight forked Vikram's queen and rook simultaneously. Vikram sat back in his chair, exhaled once, and extended his hand across the board before Deja could even reach for her own piece. "Good game," he said. "I missed that four moves ago."

Match Point (Told Backward)

1. Vikram extended his hand across the board, resigning before Deja could even move her fork-threatening knight into position to capture. "Good game," he said. "I missed that four moves ago." Deja shook his hand, still not quite believing the position in front of her.
2. Four moves earlier, that same knight had been sitting on an ordinary square, part of a quiet repositioning that Vikram's raised eyebrows suggested he had not expected. He had offered a pawn trade minutes before, certain Deja would accept it automatically, the way most players at her level did against him.
3. She had not accepted it. She had stared at the board for four full minutes, the longest she had spent on any single move all day, turning over a possibility that would not become obvious to Vikram until it was already too late to stop.
4. All of it — the four-minute pause, the declined trade, the eventual fork — traced back to a third game that had started with Deja down a rook and no clear plan, water bottle cap clicking three times as she searched for one.

Warm-up · Before You Read

1. What explicit detail does paragraph 1 of the chronological version give about Deja's standing in the match before move nineteen?
2. In the chronological version, what specific incident happens on move nineteen (paragraph 2)?

Guided Practice

3. What is the very first sentence of the backward-told version, and how does its content compare to the very last sentence of the chronological version?

4. How does starting with the resignation in the backward version immediately change what the reader is curious about, compared to the chronological version?

Guided Practice

5. Identify one sentence that appears in both versions with nearly identical wording, and explain where each version places it.

6. How does the backward version's paragraph 2 use the phrase "that same knight" to link back to paragraph 1?

Partner Discussion

7. What information is revealed in paragraph 4 of the chronological version that is instead revealed in paragraph 4 of the backward version — but described as an origin rather than a starting point?

8. Compare how each version treats the four-minute pause over move nineteen. What role does it play structurally in each version?

Partner Discussion

9. Which version's structure makes Vikram's reaction ("Good game. I missed that four moves ago.") feel more like a surprising reveal, and why?

Independent Practice

10. Which version's structure makes Deja's four-minute pause over the declined trade feel more suspenseful in the moment it happens, and why?

11. How does the chronological structure affect the story's style — is it more focused on building tension toward an unknown outcome, or explaining a known outcome? Support your answer.

Independent Practice

12. How does the backward structure affect the story's style — is it more focused on building tension, or explaining causes? Support your answer.

13. If a reader wanted to feel maximum suspense about whether Deja would win, which version should they read, and why?

Independent Practice

14. If a reader already knew Deja won and wanted to understand exactly how, which version would likely be more satisfying, and why?

15. Both versions contain the same four key incidents (the rook deficit, the declined trade, the four-minute pause, the knight fork). Explain how differing structure changes their meaning even though the events themselves do not change.

Small-Group Work

16. What explicit detail does paragraph 3 of the backward version add about the declined trade that paragraph 2 of the chronological version does not directly state?

17. How does the phrase "traced back to" in paragraph 4 of the backward version signal the text's overall structural approach?

Small-Group Work

18. Which version's final paragraph functions as a true ending, and which version's final paragraph functions as a true beginning? Explain using structure, not content.

19. If you were writing a version of this story to emphasize Vikram's perspective and surprise, which structure would you choose, and why?

Exit Ticket

20. Explain one advantage and one disadvantage of the backward structure compared to the chronological structure for a reader encountering this story for the first time.

Answer Key (1 of 4)

1. She had lost the first two games and was down a rook in the third game, with no clear plan to recover it.
2. Vikram offers a pawn trade that looks harmless, and Deja stares at the board for four minutes before declining it and repositioning her knight.
3. The backward version opens with Vikram resigning and saying "Good game. I missed that four moves ago," which is nearly identical to the ending of the chronological version — the backward version starts where the other one ends.
4. Instead of wondering how the match will end, the reader immediately knows Deja wins and instead becomes curious about how she got there — the mystery shifts from outcome to cause.
5. "Good game. I missed that four moves ago" appears at the very end of the chronological version and at the very beginning of the backward version, marking the same moment but serving opposite structural purposes: a climax versus an opening hook.

Answer Key (2 of 4)

6. It explicitly connects the knight involved in the winning fork (paragraph 1) to an earlier, seemingly ordinary moment (paragraph 2), guiding the reader backward through cause and effect rather than forward through time.

7. Deja being down a rook early in the third game with no clear plan; the chronological version starts there, while the backward version treats it as the root cause revealed only at the very end.

8. In the chronological version, the pause is presented in the moment as it happens, building suspense forward; in the backward version, the same pause is revealed partway through as an already-completed event that the reader now understands the significance of, building understanding backward.

9. The backward version makes it feel more like a reveal, because the reader encounters this line before understanding the sequence of moves that caused it, creating curiosity that the rest of the text then satisfies.

10. The chronological version makes the pause feel more suspenseful in the moment, because the reader experiences it in real time without knowing yet whether Deja's decision will succeed, unlike the backward version where the outcome is already known.

Answer Key (3 of 4)

11. It is more focused on building tension toward an unknown outcome; each paragraph moves forward in time without revealing the result, so the reader experiences uncertainty alongside Deja until the final move.

12. It is more focused on explaining causes; since the outcome is revealed immediately, each subsequent paragraph functions like an investigation working backward to explain how that outcome came to be.

13. The chronological version, because it withholds the outcome until the final paragraph, allowing suspense to build naturally as the match unfolds.

14. The backward version, because it is structured specifically to trace the causes of a known outcome, walking the reader through exactly which decisions led to the win.

15. Answers vary; should explain that in the chronological version the incidents build toward an uncertain outcome, creating suspense, while in the backward version the same incidents are revealed as an explanation for an already-known outcome, creating a sense of discovery or realization instead — the structure changes what the reader is meant to feel and focus on, even though no event itself changes.

Answer Key (4 of 4)

16. It explicitly notes the pause was "the longest she had spent on any single move all day," adding a comparative detail about the pause's length relative to the rest of her match that highlights its significance in hindsight.

17. It explicitly signals that the text is working backward from an effect to its cause, guiding the reader to understand the final paragraph as an origin point rather than a conclusion.

18. The chronological version's final paragraph is a true ending, wrapping up the sequence of events; the backward version's final paragraph is structurally a true beginning, since it describes the earliest event in time even though it appears last in the text.

19. Answers vary; a strong answer might choose the backward structure, since opening with his resignation and surprise reaction immediately centers his emotional experience, or the chronological structure, arguing that showing his growing confusion in real time (the raised eyebrows, the earlier expectation) builds his perspective more gradually.

20. An advantage is immediate intrigue, since starting with the resignation raises questions the reader wants answered; a disadvantage is reduced suspense about the outcome itself, since the reader already knows Deja wins before learning any of the details of how.

Exit Ticket

Answer on a sticky note

Answer the exit-ticket question from today's lesson.

Cite at least one piece of evidence from the passage.

Remember

Name your claim or answer

Quote or cite the evidence

Explain how it supports your answer